Employment Act: the rules that matter when covering shifts

A plain-English summary of Singapore's Employment Act for managers who roster hourly and shift staff. Figures from the Ministry of Manpower (MOM), checked October 2026.

1. Who these rules cover

- The Employment Act covers most employees in Singapore, full-time and part-time.
- **Part IV** (hours of work, overtime, rest days) covers **workmen** earning up to **S$4,500** basic a month and **other employees** earning up to **S$2,600** basic a month. Managers and executives are not covered by Part IV.
- For non-workmen, the overtime rate is capped at the S$2,600 salary level (S$13.60 an hour).

2. Hours of work

Arrangement	Normal hours allowed
Work 5 days or fewer a week	Up to 9 hours a day or 44 hours a week
Work more than 5 days a week	Up to 8 hours a day or 44 hours a week
Alternate short and long weeks	Up to 48 hours a week, but no more than 88 hours in any 2 weeks
Shift work (up to 12 hours a day)	Average of no more than 44 hours a week over any 3 continuous weeks

- **Daily limit:** no more than **12 hours** of work in a day, including overtime, except in exceptional cases (accidents, essential services, urgent work). Going up to 14 hours needs an MOM exemption.
- **Breaks:** no more than **6 consecutive hours** without a break. Where work must run continuously for up to 8 hours, give meal breaks of at least **45 minutes** in total.

3. Overtime

- Overtime is any work beyond normal contractual hours (breaks don't count).
- Pay at least **1.5×** the hourly basic rate, within 14 days after the end of the salary period.
- Cap: **72 hours of overtime a month**, unless MOM grants an exemption.
- Hourly basic rate for monthly-rated staff = (12 × monthly basic pay) ÷ (52 × 44).

4. Rest days

- Give **1 rest day a week** (midnight to midnight). It is unpaid. Shift workers may get a continuous **30-hour** rest period instead.
- No more than 12 days between rest days. Staff can't be required to work on a rest day except in exceptional circumstances.

Work on a rest day	Up to half normal daily hours	More than half	Beyond normal daily hours
At the employer's request	1 day's salary	2 days' salary	2 days' salary + overtime pay
At the employee's request	Half a day's salary	1 day's salary	1 day's salary + overtime pay

5. Sick leave

- Paid sick leave starts after **3 months** of service. Staff must tell you, or try to, **within 48 hours** of being absent, and hand in the medical certificate when they return.
- Hospitalisation leave includes the outpatient days (60 days in total, not 74).

Months of service completed	Paid outpatient sick leave	Paid hospitalisation leave
Under 3	0 days	0 days
3	5 days	15 days
4	8 days	30 days
5	11 days	45 days
6 and after	14 days	60 days

6. Annual leave

- Paid annual leave starts after **3 months** of service.

Year of service	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th +
Days of annual leave	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14

7. Part-time staff

- Part-time staff (working under 35 hours a week) get annual leave, sick leave and hospitalisation leave **pro-rated by the hours they work**, after 3 months of service. Leave is counted in hours.
- Example from MOM: someone working 20 hours a week, compared with a 44-hour full-timer on 7 days' leave and 8-hour days, gets 25.5 hours of annual leave.

8. Public holidays

- Singapore has 11 paid public holidays a year. If staff work on one, give an extra day's pay or a day off in lieu.

9. How ContinuityOS applies these rules

- Never offers a shift that would push someone past their weekly hour cap (44 hours by default).
- Keeps a minimum rest gap between shifts (10 hours by default) and gives each person at most one shift a day, which keeps everyone well inside the 12-hour daily limit.
- Never shares why someone is absent; medical reasons are not stored.
- Records every change and confirmation in an evidence log, so hours and overtime can be checked later.

Sources

MOM, Hours of work, overtime and rest days: https://www.mom.gov.sg/employment-practices/hours-of-work-overtime-and-rest-days
MOM, Sick leave eligibility and entitlement: https://www.mom.gov.sg/employment-practices/leave/sick-leave/eligibility-and-entitlement
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MOM, Leave for part-time employees: https://www.mom.gov.sg/employment-practices/part-time-employment/leave
Employment Act 1968 (full text): https://sso.agc.gov.sg/Act/EmA1968